

The Magistrate

M.E.J.Powell

him. Every advisor, who is themselves not free, that brings a proclaimed good to a ruler, only serves to entangle that good with madness. Theirs, the rulers, the people's – it's endless."

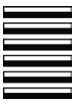
"This is evil then. This is what we must eliminate," said Dashi.

"No enemy," said the master, "Just a pretension, a charade. Evil shows up in the guise of good."

"They're pretending to be good?" asked Dashi.

"They pretend to be evil," replied the master, lighting another match, "Pretend they're not themselves." And with his breath he rekindled the embers. "Evil: is a thin gruel of miserly Joy," said the master and left off to puff his pipe.

Dashi looked out at the moon again.



One day the master said he had to attend to other matters. Dashi wanted to go with him, but the master insisted Dashi stay and concentrate on his cultivation. He acquiesced, doing as his master bid. Dashi watched the door close behind the master, leaving Dashi alone in the house of dead children.

Dashi ate some porridge. It was too cold. He could have reheated it, but he was keeping the fuel they'd collected for warmth. If he really needed to, he could crawl out through the hole in the wall and into the woods and gather more. Though truth be told, he didn't like going beneath the floor of the habitation. The cave beneath his feet he'd entered when he'd come out from the trees, felt like stepping back, and he wanted to move forward.

Dashi therefore spent the first day in bed, sitting, medi-

tating, with all the rags of comfort wrapped around for warmth. As was his habit he did the firebreath. He wondered whether any of the others who'd sat with him still did. He hoped they were safe. He burned away rising fears.

After a time he switched to forgiving practice. He found in himself many irritations. So many things that irked him. Attitudes that other people had that really made him jump. Judgments covered in prickles.

Dashi realised two things that day. Firstly that Joy, despite appearances to the contrary, was indeed under everything. No matter how bothersome their actions, nor how justified his anger, or impeccably reasoned his self-righteousness, there lived underneath, the impulse of doing. All action, all thought, all feeling stemmed from saying yes. Even saying no required you say yes. A positive affirmation of will – whatever the object. What, in its tiniest shards was difficult to make out as Joy, but in quality, in feeling, was revealed as the wage one drew to bear witness against yourself. Self in abnegation.

The other thing he realised was all of the now invisible freedoms from forgiveness opened space in his heart for serenity. The constant whir of old feeling swarming beneath his awareness he could now hear. He could pick out one, and hold it in his attention.

He might begin on a first pass, by releasing 'this,' subsequently realising the little trapped joy's spiteful pleasure. What you get out of saying yes to your sense of separateness? One mind can lose, and another win. Then that one mind can be more important. Not just presently, in this circumstance, but just so. Dashi tried to argue for it, but he couldn't argue it.

A line of principle he imagined, greater to lesser. Out-

side of which was an emptiness. If he drew the ends of the line together, the circle was just the defined temporal importance, arising, reaching the peak, and falling. Comprehension existed in the judged domain within the circle. The focus. While outside was the extreme at which thought dissolved.

What previously was undifferentiated thought, because of a wall became a belonging. Like a house, or a city. A trick of focus. And without really changing anything, focus could make the background become foreground anchored but unbounded – the so called, everything else. Not an emptiness at all. Just the unknown world.

Which is more important? The city or the land? Beyond the cropland, where the enclosure was a mere ditch, there was more. And beyond this valley, more. No matter how far out he drew the bounding circle, there was more, all just as important to what was within the circle.

He wondered if this might apply to more than land. By this time, however, the day was becoming dark. It had been overcast and although nearly spring, winter held heaven and earth in its grip.

Dashi reheated the porridge too hot. He put out a bowl for the master. The master did not return. Dashi returned to the bed and cultivating his minds, fell asleep. In the morning he thomped downstairs expecting to see the master but was met only by the table, the chairs, and the bowl of porridge now gone cold.

On the second day, Dashi either sat at the table most of the day, or paced about it. He opened the hatch to the cave, thinking he might escape and go wandering about in the woods beyond but the master had asked him to clear his minds. Dashi closed the door to the forest.

As he walked the boards he became again magistrate

and pontificated, sometimes aloud, his opinions on statecraft and public welfare. "One pretends to be something one is not when one pretends to not be something one is," he said to the imagined crowd. They nodded.

"The seen is not separated from the seer. Nothing can be outside of the whole."

"*Ah...*" they replied.

"Our inherited longings, are chosen by nature – to drive you, to drive everyone. We cannot help but create them in our external world. In the desire's fulfillment you benefit the tribe, and its future generations. It is because of these conditions that the individual minds are the ones they are," he said to them, but really he was wondering where the granddaughter was. He hoped she was safe.

Someone in the crowd asked about stuckness. To which Dashi replied, "The single minded pursuit of any end will be its downfall. Even the consciousness which divides heaven and earth and thinks it understands something will be without recourse in the end."

Someone popped up in the back and said, *Recourse to what?*

Dashi didn't know. He went back to bed to think about it. "Sanity," he replied, lying there. "To hear only your own voice, to see only your own reflection, to be solitary is to go mad – for one mind, for one person, for an empire."

The crowd nodded. *Then why do people go along with the group?* said the same voice, popping up from the otherwise awed gathering. Annoyed, Dashi wondered, who was this?

He answered, "Groups of followers have leaders. A true leader comes out of the one within, becomes the many minds and returns to the one just as the oak grows from an acorn, and in its maturity it creates them.

"If you do not live your own nature it's just another game to win. Leadership will be filled with predators playing for power. Thus the followers – grovellers – echo whatever they see as powerful, cooperating only to maintain their supply. Truth becomes flexible. Understood as only a way to get what is desired. Thus when the powerful fail – their followers disavow.

"Everything is about their nourishment but nothing else is nourished, everything is about power, but nothing lasting is achieved. The small are crowded out, nature is abused, and under the regimes, food becomes scarce or tainted. Because they do not care. Because they have chosen the tactical means of a predator, and not the greater one."

Isn't a magistrate, a judge life and death, also then a predator? asked Dashi's heckler.

"Absolutely," Dashi said to himself, "A predator of predators." That seemed to shut him up, finally. Dashi stared at the stained ceiling for awhile. Then he got up again.

He thought of leaving to look for food, but one mind pointed out he'd no money, and if spotted he'd be arrested and also the reason he wanted to defy the master's request was, he admitted to himself, to be a rebel – just for the fun of it.

He sat. "I embrace the Joy in being the defiant one," Dashi began his absolution. How many times he wondered had he made a decision that changed the destiny of his life because at the time he felt a tiny spark of spite. An attempt to regain some power. A mind remembering itself as a small child with the desire to choose its own way.

A wind blew the door open again, as it had when he and the captain had met here. Dashi got up and closed it tight, and then he wondered – how his friend was faring, a war-

rior, unable to hide like he, a thief in the night, with the ingrained instinct to run.

This Dashi realised was the humour in the tragedy – the compassion and the humanness of all evil – these natural childish desires. How could any of us know they would become mistakes? – a little decision – made in innocence – that dooms us. A perfection of means ending in an unseemly confusion of character. The only way to do better, to see further, was to cultivate the temporal minds, to free them to see over the horizon as they'd adapted to do. To open ourselves to our own Joy.

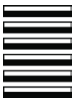
Dashi sat with his back against the wall. "I embrace... release... free... embrace... release... free... embrace... release... free... embrace... release... free..." he chanted sometimes aloud, sometimes within himself.

Dashi spent the next day removing more. And the next day after. And he only thought of soup and noodles and dumplings seven times.

The master returned three days later in a sombre mood. He was quiet. He greeted his student, handed him the book he'd recommended, but then said nothing for hours.

Dashi didn't feel like pestering him with questions.

Eventually the master said to Dashi, "In life, you may see something so terrible it will disturb you," he looked off. "It's hard to imagine the beginning mistake that ends in so malevolent an insanity," the master said, "and yet realise there are no enemies – that good and bad are ideals... But one can be put on the spot to choose to champion nature, when others have chosen to play monster." And the master spoke no more, and they remained in silence together until late when the master said, "I'm tired of porridge."



Thudding thunder spilled down the streets. Stomp. Stomp. Stomp-stomp-stomp! And again – Stomp. Stomp. Stomp-stomp-stomp! And again.

When Dashi and the master arrived, the square was a smoke-filled gyre. Whizzing pinwheels were being set off, sparks firing with swelling plumes. Their faces painted, masked with mud, and blood – the crowd circled – from just in front of the stage, all the way to the outer buildings. As they completed their orbit around the fuming fire surrounded by rocks, at the centre, they spun themselves around. They flopped their red rag limbs and legs. They lolled their heads. They gaped and gasped and muttered and mouthed.

The master and he stood behind a small immobile group holding vigil agape. They wound their way past. Looking to the side, Dashi noted bored treasury guards leaning against the walls, their rifles asleep in their hands, only rousing themselves to push away those bodies reeling back onto the wheel.

He could also see those slumped against the wall, not seated, nor fallen over in exhaustion, nor even as if they'd been dragged or dumped there, but rather kicked to the side of the great gyre by the stomping swarm. Not far, a woman had fallen in such a position that the dancers, as they passed, kicked her in the face. Dashi, eyeing the indifferent guard warily, waded in and pulled her into the street. The angle of her head slumped unusually as he eased her to the ground. The master knelt down, touching her neck.

She was dead.

Dashi closed her bloodied staring eyes, "Master, what

is happening?"

"They are sleepwalking. Or rather – sleepdancing," the master said.

"But how? Master?" said Dashi desperate to understand, turning his face from the in-repose corpse to the ones still twirling. From beyond the stomping he could hear the voice calling out to them. A hoarse, howling yelling, bellowing.

"Be you! – So whatever you're doing... it's you... doing it... for free-eee!" said the caterpillar, extending the word in giddy laughter, "'Cause the future is e-v-e-r-y-thing!" he growled and anticlimactically complaining into his cup, "Wretches... I never...get anything I want... I don't care," and sloughing back into his chair, he drank, spilling wine from the goblet over himself, then held it out briefly toasting the dancers, before drinking it dry and banging it on the armrest to be refilled, in a tantrum of rage.

Dashi could just make out the sound of polite applause. Peering over the crush, he saw the thrashing caterpillar was back in his palanquin, rushing attendants seeking to mollify, the magistrate's chair beside him, empty.

It was then he realised the crowd was chanting with their breathing, whispered so low and drowned by their thudding feet he hadn't heard. Droning, "share... unfair... share..." and so on, they made their procession.

Another came into view on the stage. It was the court clerk pulling a stand, a megaphone affixed to its top, to the front of the stage before the red chair. Then he retreated. Another came and adjusted it. Then the stage was empty. Some small movement caught his eye. Dashi went on his toes to see. Barely could he make out the bobbing heads of what appeared to be naked forms, fornicating en masse up against one side of the stage. Aside from that,

Maturation is natural.

Dashi greatest desire was always to help the people. Now he has the power. But it's worse that difficult – it's politics.

"Don't add to their lives, remove obstacles. Teach people how to feel relief. Don't belabour that it's good for them. That's just giving them the temptation to give themselves airs. Or for you to pat yourself on the back for being beneficent."

Thus begins the sly teaching of the mistress. If only Dashi can understand the entangled layers of what she really intends. As if that weren't enough – a secret is unearthed. And another – buried in the minds of the people.

With the master absent, he's going to need to do more than trust himself – just to survive. And more than just survive to come closer to answering the question: Who are you?



M.E.J. Powell, an expert on being immature, extends to you a somewhat less gentle satire on the nature of individual maturation and its societal implications.

Returning after three years, with the second book in the trilogy, to answer the burning question about the minds – how can they get along with each other? And by extension, how can society get along with itself?

KINGFISHER SPARROW